# Rocco Cuffari

## Principal Cloud & AI Architect

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## PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Enterprise architect with 27 years of IT experience and a focused practice in AI transformation, secure cloud architecture, and regulated-environment adoption. Over the past three years, led 50+ customer engagements across defense (CMMC/NIST), higher education, healthcare, financial services, and state and local government - designing enterprise AI operating models, productizing secure generative AI offerings on Azure, and enabling executive and engineering teams to adopt AI responsibly. Holds 18 active Microsoft certifications including Cybersecurity Architect Expert, Azure Solutions Architect Expert, AI Transformation Leader, and Azure AI Engineer Associate. Known for translating AI ambition into production-ready architecture and operating model decisions that organizations can build, govern, and scale.

## MICROSOFT CERTIFICATIONS

**18 active certifications · 20 exams passed · 146 modules completed · 107 training hours**

Cybersecurity Architect Expert · Azure Solutions Architect Expert · AI Transformation Leader · Azure AI Engineer Associate · Azure Security Engineer Associate · Azure Administrator Associate · Azure Virtual Desktop Specialty · Security, Compliance & Identity Fundamentals · Azure AI Fundamentals · Azure Fundamentals

## CORE COMPETENCIES

Enterprise AI Operating Model Design · Secure Generative AI Deployment (Azure OpenAI / AI Foundry) · AI Governance & Responsible AI Frameworks · Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) & Agentic Workflows · Azure Landing Zone Architecture · Zero Trust Identity & Access (PIM, Conditional Access) · NIST 800-171 / 800-53 & CMMC Compliance · Executive Workshop Facilitation & AI Enablement · Multi-cloud Architecture (Azure, AWS, Hybrid) · Microsoft Sentinel / SIEM / SOAR

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

### AHEAD

February 2025 – Present

*Principal Technical Consultant, AI & Azure* • Chicago, IL

#### AI Transformation & Enterprise Operating Model

- Authored AHEAD's Private AI operating model - a vendor-agnostic framework for responsible generative AI adoption across identity, security, networking, and compliance, now used as a delivery foundation across customer engagements.
- Designed a Crawl, Walk, Run adoption framework guiding customers from AI experimentation through pilot and into governed production operations, with defined governance checkpoints at each stage.
- Created reference architectures covering retrieval pipelines, prompt evaluation, agentic workflows, and secure hosting patterns aligned to enterprise IT and regulatory standards.
- Developed and facilitated executive and engineering workshops aligning stakeholders on AI integration, platform decisions, and governance requirements.
- Produced standardized delivery artifacts: governance packages, indexing patterns, retrieval tuning profiles, and production readiness assessments.
- Documented multi-cloud AI deployment patterns across Azure, AWS, and hybrid estates with identity-driven controls, protected connectivity, and consistent retrieval behavior.

#### Azure Architecture & Cloud Security

- Lead architect for Azure landing zones across hub-spoke and isolated environments, shaping management group structure, subscription strategy, policy baselines, and network segmentation.
- Architected enterprise retrieval and grounding experiences for approximately 5,000 users, integrating Azure AI Search with Fabric, SQL databases, document stores, and Blob Storage.

- Implemented identity-first access patterns for VMs, PaaS services, and AI workloads using PIM, Conditional Access, and managed identities.
- Built structured observability patterns using Azure Monitor, Log Analytics, and Sentinel with diagnostic mapping, dashboards, and secure ingestion paths.
- Supported regulated environments aligned to NIST 800-171 and NIST 800-53 across storage, access, retention, and monitoring layers.

**Planet Technologies** August 2022 – February 2025

*Azure Architect* • Germantown, MD

- Delivered 30+ customer engagements across defense (CMMC/NIST), higher education research, healthcare (academic medical centers and hospital systems), financial services, and state and local government.
- Developed and productized the firm's Private AI Platform offering - a secure Azure OpenAI deployment behind private endpoints enabling enterprise customers to run generative AI within their existing security perimeter, iterated through the evolution from Azure OpenAI to Azure AI Foundry.
- Built a repeatable engagement model: multi-day discovery and architecture workshops with customer IT teams and leadership, tailored Azure landing zone design from workshop outputs, and IaC-based deployment delivering consistent, documented environments across a diverse customer base.
- Established AI governance boards, decision frameworks, and communication structures for NIST- and CMMC-aligned organizations at the start of their AI adoption journeys.
- Developed and delivered AI workshop curriculum for seasoned IT professionals and IT leadership, covering responsible AI, governance, Azure AI architecture, identity, security, and operational readiness.
- Designed secure research enclave environments in Azure for data science programs in higher education, meeting regulatory and isolation requirements.
- Integrated Microsoft Sentinel for SIEM/SOAR across multiple large-scale engagements, including compliance mapping, detection engineering, and security alerting architecture.

**DynTek** August 2021 – August 2022

*Principal Architect* • Las Vegas, NV

- Provided Microsoft-centric pre-sales technical support for a national sales team, architecting solutions across Azure, Microsoft 365, and security aligned to customer requirements.
- Created Statements of Work and technical proposals for complex Microsoft-platform engagements; managed Microsoft partner relationships and go-to-market positioning.

**Jones Day** October 2016 – August 2021

*Senior Messaging Engineer & Infrastructure Lead* • Cleveland, OH

- Senior technical contributor on a multi-year, $50M+ global IT transformation covering desktop OS modernization, mobility platform migration, Notes-to-Exchange, and Windows Server and VMware infrastructure upgrades across a global Am Law 100 law firm.
- Led global architecture and deployment of Exchange 2016; migrated 6,000+ mailboxes from Lotus Notes to Exchange. Defined RBAC and audit logging standards and authored operational runbooks for patch management and hardening.

**TrustPoint Technologies** 2014 – 2018 (full-time through 2016, part-time through 2018)

*Operations Manager* • Cleveland, OH

- Managed operations of a $10M technology services firm with 13 direct reports across technical delivery, support, and administrative functions.
- Founded and built the firm's Microsoft practice from the ground up, launching their first Azure-based business continuity and disaster recovery offerings and expanding the firm's cloud services capability.
- Oversaw service delivery, vendor relationships, and client accounts while the firm scaled its managed services and consulting practice.

**Earlier Technical Roles · 1999–2013**

Senior Consultant, ProSource Solutions · Systems Administrator, City of Cleveland · Network & Server Support, Sapphire Technologies / Devore Technologies / Robert Half International

## INDEPENDENT PRACTICE

### Humindful.com

2023 – Present

*Founder & Principal AI Advisor* • Strongsville, OH

- Develop and deliver AI transformation workshops and curriculum at Cuyahoga Community College (Tri-C) and for corporate, healthcare, legal, and government audiences, helping executive and non-technical decision-makers understand and act on AI adoption.
- Keynote speaker on practical AI adoption and workforce readiness at the Greater Cleveland Chamber of Commerce (100+ attendees).
- Published white papers and articles on AI readiness, governance, and workforce transformation for practitioners and business leaders.
- Deliver Career Resilience Roadmap workshops supporting community members navigating AI-driven workforce change.
- Faculty Fellow – The Center for the Future of Work – Cuyahoga Community College
- Adjunct Professor - Cuyahoga Community College

**Board Member, MDC Iowa** - Support minority-owned technology startups through investment and advisory contributions.